No. 117

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Secrets of the Jungle

Dawn was approaching. The sun poked its head out from where sea and sky met. All that could be seen along the coast was some seabirds hopping around in search of their morning meal and the silhouette of a canoe. Two figures got off the canoe, dragged themselves onto the bank and pulled a heavy rugsack off the canoe.

One of the figures spoke. "Would you get on with it?" The gruff voice showed its impatience, "Toss it over your shoulder and carry it."

The other figure grunted. "Sure, sure! Well it's not just one ingot we're dealing with..."

He was rudely interrupted by the first figure, who was trying to quietly scream at him: "Would you shut up?!

Just move, Han!"

After a few seconds of lugging the rugsack in silence, a spark flickered in Han's exhausted eyes. He said in a low voice: "Bao, you've got the thorns, haven't you?"

Bao snickered while patting his bulging backpack. "I sure do."

The two hunters crept into the dim forest not yet lit by the rising sun. Slowly and cautiously, they eased their way forward through the thick jungle, passing twisting vines and huge leaves.

"How can there be any place we can dig in this mucky moss?" Questioned Han, stomping at the wet green undergrowth.

"Just move on! We just need to get deeper into the forest." Came the plain reply from Bao.

So they ventured on, deeper and deeper into the forest. At last, when all that could be seen was the weary faces of Han and Bao, they decided to make it the place.

Bao pulled out two shovels from the backpack and tossed them onto the wet forest floor. "Let's start digging." He ordered.

For quite some time, all that could be heard in the jungle was the chirping of birds, the clanking of shovels and the slithering of creatures lurking in the darkness.

After quite some time, Bao broke the silence. "That should be it." He grunted. Thrusting his backpack down, Bao took out a neat little bottle and opened. Carefully, he poured the contents of the bottle into the previously dug pit while Han emptied

the rugsack. There was a furious clattering of metal as everything slipped into place. Cautiously covering the now full hole with dirt, the two hunters again, began their trek to return to their canoe.

The two giggled and laughed hideously on their way, telling stories and imagining the situation when a most unfortunate person comes seeking for the buried treasure, how excited he would be when finding the ingots, and finally, how painfully he would die of the poisonous thorns.

The leaves gradually thinned, revealing the sunlit coast in the distance. With cheers of joy and delight, Han and Bao paced up and rushed to their canoe still on the beach, a tiny black spot. Finally, after weeks of hard work, they've

triumphed. They've hidden the treasure, which no one — other than themselves, can claim without paying the ultimate price : life.

Just as they reached the canoe, a flash of green "flew" from the boards straight at Han. The green flash launched itself with such force that Han fell over.

There was no time to react. Bao turned and fled, leaving the triangular-headed porsonous snake and Han behind, into the deep jungle. Behind him, the horrified scream of Han shook the island, ripping at Bao's heart. The victory from moments ago felt like a dream...

But he kept on. He staggered when his shoe got caught in the strong roots of a tree, and went on barefoot. His feet became numb.

Still, he fled, away from the snake, away from the canoe, and away from his companion, who now lay motionless on the shore, dead.

All Bao was thinking about was getting away as fast as he can, so he didn't feel the softness of a pit beneath his feet, nor the piercing of something sharp into his bare foot.

It was not long before Bao tumbled to the ground, panting hard, and it was then that he felt it. The pain unravelling.

Then, it all came to him. He had stepped onto the very hole he dug himself, full of tiny thorns.

Bao lay down onto the wet forest floor. Somewhere in the distance, a raven squaked.

The Sun was high in the sky,

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shining onto a tiny island in the middle of the Pacific. There, lay two corpses and a hole full of ingots.

no. title.

The world became silent all of a sudden. It felt like a second ago it was still bright outside, but now the buzzing mosquitos and the noisy cicadas have all gone to sleep. Even the God of wind had tightened his wind pouch for the night, only letting gentle zephyrs stir the night air. The hustle and bustle of city night life seemed to calm down, the street lamps shone their warm rays onto the empty streets. The Moon was high in the sky, casting a silver mist over the horizen. All was quiet, all was darkness, apart from a window where light shone.

If you have peered into the window, you would see the

silohuette of a kid, about 10 years old, sitting at a desk, doing homework. That was me.

I was tired of my life. The stacks of homework yet to be finished were giving me headaches. Sleep was implausible, let alone time to have fun. It seem as if I was trapped in lifelong misery, that I was nothing more than a learning machine. I was a lost soul.

I yawned. I heard the distant chiming of the clock tower and counted the low bongs. One, two, ..., eleven, twelve. Great. It was midnight.

If only I could finish that pile of homework in time! Solumnly, I counted the pages. There was no end.

I decided to dose. Just 5 minutes would do!

I was asleep before I made myself comfortable, sprawling onto the desk. Conciousness slipped away along with all the misery. It was the first time in 48 hours that I dared to doze.

Suddenly I was aware again. I could feel myself, and abruptly opened my eyes, expecting to see homework awaiting. Instead, what I "saw" shocked me —— emptiness! All around me was darkness, but there was light at the same time. There was silence, along with crazy music that words could not describe.

Where was I? I looked around, and found myself hanging in midair! I thrashed around wildly and screamed, but no sound came out. Was this a dream? I

pulled at my eyelids, willing myself to wake up with all effort.

Still, nothing happened.

Again, I struggled in vain to yell for help. Nothing came out. Tears poured down my face while cold sweat trickled down my spine. I wanted to go home! Any amount of homework is better than being nowhere!

Then, to my horror, I heard a voice boom so loud that I wasn't sure whether it came from a distance or spoke directly into my head.

"Kid, you're not going anywhere."

I shivered. My heart almost stopped beating. The voice was cold, unsympathetic. Fear gnawed at my insides.

"You're not going anywhere." The voice repeated itself.

There was quite a pause. I shuddered.

Slowly and powerfully, syllable by syllable, the voice pounded at me.

"Because YOU ARE NOT REAL!" Boomed the voice."

Questions swarmed into my head, but there was no way that I could let them out.

"YOUR WHOLE WORLD IS AN ILLUSION!"

The voiced drained away, but repeated itself again and again, buzzing inside my head.

So I was stuck nowhere? All my past 10 years of life was an illusion?! I was scared, out of wits.

But before I could react, a powerful force thrusted me hard, out and away. I drifted

through thin air, and then I was falling, falling...

The next thing I knew that it was morning. The Sun beamed at me, birds chirped, and cicadas sang their noisy songs.

Wait... I was back, at home, sitting at my desk!

All of a sudden, the terrible memory and the voice came back: *you are not real... your world is an illusion...*

I shivered. In panic, I shook myself. Slowly and carefully, I ran my fingers along my desk, my lamp (which was still on despite it was morning), and my own face. Everything felt real! Or was it... an illusion?

The sun focused its rays on my homework. A breeze rustled the pages of an open workbook. Outside,

the world was full of life. Things seemed, all of a sudden, so pleasant, and I was filled with a feeling that I haven't had for a long time: happiness!

Then, it all came to me. No matter the world is an illusion or not, I would enjoy each and every moment of life. I was grateful for "the illusion", grateful that I was alive. I shouldn't put so much pressure on myself! -

With that, I thrust my homework out of the window.

I knew instantly that I have freed my soul.

Robot

I could still vaguely remember the last moments that I was really me, when I was still in my original but crippled body. My legs hurt all over. I was carried into a bright operation room with masked doctors. Nearby, a robot waited. A robot in wait to have life inplanted. A robot that shall be the focus of future scientific research. A robot that looked exactly like me.

I was so grateful that everything worked fine. I was a little bit dizzy when I awoke. It felt the same as waking up from a night's sleep.

It took about a week for me to get used to the robotic

body. After all, I had been confined to a wheelchair for the past two years. Everything seemed and felt new to me, like I was reborn.

For the first time in the past two years, I was happy. It felt as if nothing would go wrong.

It turned out that there were serious issues.

It began when I saw myself on the newspaper, a few days after the great operation. After all, I was a volunteer in this experiment concerning life and death, the first — the pioneer — in this whole new field of science!

I logged onto my old account on social media, which hasn't been used for years. All the articles, all the headlines were about me!

The cripple on the threshold of life and death whose brain got put in a robot!

I had become a celebrity overnight. At first, I enjoyed all the attention, but soon things started to get annoying. Day after day, media reporters knocked at my door asking the same questions. Letters flooded in from all around the world, leaving me with mounts of paperwork to deal with.

That was not all. I had to make weekly appointments to the experimental lab and go have "health checks". On the way I often got stopped in the middle of the road by someone asking for my autograph while others pulled out their phones and took my picture — without my permission! That really pissed me off, but

whenever I tried to refuse or fight back, something weird takes place and I had to involuntarily do as ordered by the offender.

Maybe it was the robotic part of me acting up. Programming overpowered my real, human brain and I had to live up to the Three Laws of Robotics. But I was still human, I thought human, slept human... Other than a few daily procedures that I had to do to keep myself running, sleeping on a wireless charger, injecting energy and protein to sustain my brain, I was no less human than anyone else!

Walking on the street, I could hear people whispering "robot" under their breath and looking strangely at me, which

made me feel like a pariah in human society.

The worst things happened yesterday, on my way to the experimental lab. Off the corner of my eye, a group of ill-intentioned teenage boys strided towards me. I ran, afraid of what they might do to me. But my robotic body was not built for running. The pounding footsteps caught up, and all of a sudden my left arm was clentched by a strong hand. Even though I couldn't feel pain, I felt the violence intended.

"You're the robot, aren't you?" came a cold voice.

I could feel my mind go out of control. For a split second my arm went into defence mode, but realising this would hurt a

human being, it loosened.

I knew that help would come, there were security triggers somewhere in me. But... when?

To put a long story short, I was beaten. I didn't do anything wrong, but trouble seemed to find me anyway.

I sat in the science lab with my left arm dangling in a weird position. That's when I started thinking: why are there laws to protect humans but no law to protect robots? Or at least, laws to protect robotic humans?

Then, everything flooded into my mind. Memories from the past, before my operation and all that happened after I became "the robot". I was suddenly overwhelmed

by philosophical questions swirling in my puny human mind.

Is life without dignity really worth living?

Do I still count as a human?

Will there be more human minds put into robots?

What is the purpose of living anyways?

There are no answers to these questions. At least, the human brain inside a robot didn't find any.

No. 1

DATE 7 / 9 / 2021

The spirit of nature

"Good night, Emit!" My parents yelled from downstairs.

I sighed and mumbled back. The thing was that my parents didn't like me, the eight-year-old boy, instead they cooed over the two-year-old baby, my little sister Amber.

My parents were the sort of people that cared about nothing other than their own benefit. My mom often tore paper from my notebooks to blow her nose, while my dad smoked on the front porch and drove on the lawn with his car that gave off a nasty stench. They practically think the world exists for their own well-being!

I, on the other hand, was treated like a slave around the house. I had to do the laundry, clean the floor, wash the dishes ... All the household chores.

I sighed and made myself comfortable under the covers. There's no use complaining about things. My heavy eyelids dropped and my mind drifted into dreamland.

The next thing I knew was that it was morning. I was in dad's smelly old car, with mom and dad in the front and Amber in her crib beside me.

I yawned. "Where are we going?"

My mom jumped up enthusiastically and bumped her head on the car roof. "We're going to a nature reserve —— as a family! We shall

have picnics, play on the meadows, and enjoy the beautiful sights!"

At the sound of "family", I knew that this wouldn't have a happy ending — usually.

We arrived at the park, found a shady clearing among the trees and had our lunch of grilled bacon sandwiches. Mom was an awful cook. The bacon was overcooked, bitter and flakey at the taste.

Dad fed Amber some gross green muck. Apparantly, Amber was not so satisfied with the food offered. She whacked at the spoon with her chubby baby hands, spilling the muck all over dad's pants.

Torturing me was enough, but why Amber? She hasn't done anything wrong! (By second thought, neither have

I!)

That's when I decided that I shall leave the sorcerer and the witch; the knight was off to seek revenge and one day he shall return, to rescue the young princess in evil hands!

I threw the sandwich down and darted away, deeper into the forest; away from the selfish sorcerer, away from the wicked witch!

I was panting. My throat pained of thirst. My legs ached from the fleeing. Tripping over a root, I stumbled and fell. I crashed into fallen pine needles and twigs. ouch.

I lay there, beaten and exhausted. All that I could hear was my own thumping heartbeat. Should I turn back? No, certainly not back to the

evil lords. That's when the knight realised that he was empty-handed — he needed a weapon.

Lying lazily on the dry forest floor, I felt around for something hard, maybe a strong branch. Poking my fingers under a pile of dry leaves, I felt something hard. My fingers closed around it and pulled it towards me. It was a weirdly shaped stick, with vines wrapped around and around it. At one end, there was a handle. Holding it up and examining it closely, I found to my surprise that it had words carved into it, but the words were too small for me to read.

Using it as a cane, I helped myself up. The stick was about waist high, and then I realised

it was more like a staff than a stick. I raised it; a cool breeze swept by, rustling the leaves by my feet. Weird. This was a perfectly sunny day at the turn of spring and summer, so the breeze came from nowhere. And how could it be cool? Maybe it's just my imagination.

I walked forward, using the staff as a walking stick. I suddenly felt powerful, energy ran through me; magically, I could somehow hear the trees singing their beautiful songs and feel nature as a whole.

As I walked on, the forest thinned, giving way to a vast meadow with rising slopes and green, green grass. Of three sides of the meadow stood tall pines, a dark shade of green. Farther away stood a few rocky hills,

towering over the forest. Puffy white clouds glided in the blue, blue sky, so graceful that they were almost a flock of flying sheep.

I heard the churning of water. There must be a stream nearby! Driven by thirst, I dashed towards the sound.

There it was! The clear ripples shone like crystals. I rolled down a grass-covered hill, head over heels with excitement and knelt besides the stream. Carefully not to disturb the flow of the water, I scooped up some water with my hands and drank, like there was no tomorrow. How could that be enough? I dunked my face into the stream, drank and drank, until my stomach

couldn't hold on any longer.

Taking the last sip, I raised my head. To my astonishment, I discovered that I was not the only being beside the river.

* * *

[Meanwhile, in the forest]

The parents of Emit, namely Nora and Hoshe, yelled angrily at their naughty son who bolted away. But Emit did not stop. Hoshe, who was feeding Amber, thrust the baby girl into Nora's lap and strided into the direction where Emit's footsteps faded.

Nora yelled at Hoshe to return. "The little pest would come back. Let's just enjoy ourselves — without the little brute."

So they picnicked on.

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A young deer about my hight with white spots on his beautiful brown fur coat shimmered in the sun, glowing.

For a moment we gazed into each other's eyes; I could somehow feel the spirit of nature in the deer's deep, searching eyes. Then, its gaze fell on the staff lying on the ground.

The deer jerked its head up and... spoke!

"Did you find this?" Its voice was warm like the sun, gentle like the breeze, lively as the stream.

I was dumbfounded, fixed to the spot. All that I did was nod.

The deer pondered my nod speculatively. Then, with a sence

of urgency in its voice, it spoke again: "Come. You must meet Vor. Ride on my back."

I watched the deer swiftly hop across the stream and kneel down. I was stunned, not knowing what to do. The deer ushered me on with a clomp of its back hoof. Hesitantly and clumsily, I climbed onto its back.

Instantly, the world flew past me. Wind swept by, rustling the grass, disturbing the calm surface of the stream.

We, the deer and me, dashed over rolling hills and into the forest. Deeper and deeper we went, until we reached a place where vines tagled and twisted beneath a canopy of leaves. Looking beyond, I saw four figures beside

a stone table. As we approached, I saw that there was an elderly man with silvery white hair along with three monkeys around a table, playing cards!

At the sight of me and the deer, the man lay his cards on the stone table and stood up, facing me and the deer.

"What brings you here, Mire?" Asked the elderly man in a deep, soothing tone.

I got off Mire the deer. Mire bowed, so I did too. I peered up and examined the elderly man closely. The most remarkable feature was his silver beard that reached to the ground, glowing like the moon.

Mire spoke to the man.

"Uor, I believe that your lost

staff has been found. This young child here is Emit. Emit, meet Uor Hatikvah, Guardian of nature."

Uor extended his hand to shake, and I clumsily shook it. Not knowing what to say, I merely uttered: "Thank you, nice to meet you."

Uor shook his head wildly, his silvery beard flying left and right. "No thanks, no thanks." He reminded me of my grandfather who lived very far away in a distant land. He continued: "So my long lost staff found you, little Emit?"

I nodded. "I found the staff in a pine forest, under some dry leaves. I'm sincerely sorry! I didn't know it was yours! And I shouldn't have taken it!"

Uor interrupted my apology

with a wave of his hand.

"Child! There's no reason to be sorry!" He almost screamed.

Then, he extended his neck like a giraffe. He said mysteriously, "Nobody can find my staff. The staff found you, my friend. It is destiny that brings you into the world of nature. So now, the staff is no longer mine. It is yours."

I gazed up in astonishment as Uor spoke. There were billions of questions swirling inside my mind. "I... I don't understand!" I exclaimed.

Uor stood up. That was when I saw his watery robes, clear as the water in the stream. With a wave of his hand, he said in a mix of excitement and impatience:

"No questions for now. Come on, let's go for a little walk in the forest." Then, he gestured for me to pick up the staff. I picked it up hesitantly. Just as when I first found the staff, I was again filled with power.

In a series of swift movements, Uor gracefully strided into the forest, leaving Mire and me jogging to keep up.

After a short silence of the three of us walking in the forest, Uor spoke.

"Mire, I believe that we have to tell the child everything." Then, Uor looked at me questioningly. "What's your name again, child? Pardon me, I'm not so good at remembering humans."

I replied awkwardly. "I'm

Emit Tevaa, sir."

"Don't call me 'sir'! That's for arrogant, self-centered humans! Just call me Uor."

A short pause.

Uor continued. "Mire, tell Emit."

Mire nodded and began.

"A long time ago there were people in this forest. Nasty people, hunters, who chased us and killed us for food. Then exactly 100 years ago, a special child was born in the hunter tribe. This child had great passion for nature, and when he was taught to hunt at the age of ten he refused to fire his gun. Fed up with all the killing of animals, he ran away from his tribe and started protecting animals. He fought with other

hunters and alerted animals of danger. Gradually, he learned the languge of nature; and we, the animals, crowned him 'Guardian of Nature'".

At this point, I looked up at Vor. He was slightly blushing, and one could easily see his effort to hold a wide grin.

"It was you, wasn't it?" I fixed my gaze on Vor.

He nodded and grinned.

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[Meanwhile...]

Nora and Hoshe were getting fed up with their picnic.

"It should be time to leave." grunted Hoshe.

"But where is that dammed son of ours?" Cried Nora.

Hoshe cursed under his breath. He pulled out a cigarette and

lighted it. He often did this when he was anxious.

Then, an idea sparked in Nora's evil eyes.

"Hey," sneered Nora, "why don't we give the wimp a signal?"

"what signal?" Hoshe replied mindlessly, puffing out a cloud of grey smoke.

"We light a fire."

Any sensible person would know what lighting a fire in the middle of the forest meant, but no, Nora and Hoshe didn't care about nature. What they desperately wanted was to force "the wimp" back to them.

At this point, the two-year-old started crying. Nobody knew the exact reason why she cried, but one thing was certain: she was

afraid of what might happen, feared for the safety of the forest and her eight-year-old brother.

"AMBER!" Nora yelled, "STOP THE RACKET!!"

But this only made Amber cry harder, and thus, her furious mother slapped her on the face.

"Don't mind that baby; just build the fire." Muttered Hoshe.

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[Two miles away, in the forest]

I felt a sudden pain coming from nowhere. Then I remembered. The knight's promise. The princess in the hands of the evil sorcerer and wicked witch. Amber! I almost forgot my sister!

An idea flew into my mind. Maybe Vor and all the forest friends — the animals could help!

Mire went on to talk about the

magical staff, but I was barely listening —— all my thoughts were about Amber!

"... Vor got lost when he was chasing a group of hunters away. The woods thickened, and finally he realized the tough situation. Then, Vor spotted light up ahead. He carried on towards it and found a tremendous, old tree that seemed to glow. Vor carefully approached it and knelt before the tree. He could feel the spirit embedded within the roots of the tree —— the spirit of nature."

"Suddenly, Vor saw something glimmer before his knees. He hadn't seen it previously. Brushing aside some fallen leaves, he found that this was a staff —— the staff that you now hold in your very

own hands, Emit! Did you notice the strange carvings on the staff? It was said that they were ancient, powerful magic spells that nobody could decypher. Emit?"

I had stopped. There was something in my nose. I sniffed. Then I realized that it was the smell. Something didn't smell right.

A shock shook me. "Smoke!" I yelled, "There might be a fire! In the forest!"

Everybody tensed.

Uor gave quick orders. "Mire, carry Emit to the fire. Emit, you'll know what to do."

I was totally confused. What could I, an eight-year-old do in case of a forest fire?

Before I could react, Mire knelt beside me and Uor ushered

me onto the deer's back. Then, I was flying through the forest, again.

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"Yikes! Dammed wind! The fire's getting out of control!" Cried Nora.

"Burn down the forest and we'll find the wimp!" Yelled Hoshe over the crackling flames.

"Good idea, but what if we get in the fire's way?"

"RUN!" Screamed Hoshe.

And the two brutal parents bolted away, leaving the remains of their picnic and their two-year-old daughter on the edge of the fire.

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It was heating up. I could hear the crackling of flames nearby.

"There!" I spotted the flames, to the left.

Mire sped straight towards the flames. A moment later, we were facing a wall of fire that stretched into the sky, advancing towards us.

All that we could do was back away. Then, Mire's sharp deer ears perked up. She dashed swiftly toward the right, along the firewall.

"Where are you...?" My voice was swallowed by the crackling flames.

"Shh! Listen!" Mire shushed me.

I could vaguely hear crying. A sharp knife pierced into my bare heart. Amber! She's in the fire!

"Amber, hold on! I'm coming for you!" I yelled out loud.

Amber's crying ceased when she heard me call. I knew that

I had to react — fast!

I felt a tingling feeling in my right hand and arm, which held the staff. Yes, the staff! Pain washed over me as I felt the same agony of the burning trees. If only I could get water to extinguish the fire...

Water... Water!

Flashbacks of the stream rushed into my mind. Quiverring, I raised the staff, the magical staff that bore all hope of saving the forest and my sister.

I concentrated hard.

"Stream!" I thought with all my will.

The image of the stream floated into my mind.

"Water!" I thought. I was shaking all over.

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As my body was beside the fire, in my mind I was next to the stream, and there was the miracle —— water rose from the stream and flowed in air towards the tip of my staff.

The water was getting heavier. I could feel it physically. Then, I raised my head up, clenching the staff that now weighed a ton. Looking up, I was startled to see that a giant puddle, no, lake of water had accumilated in the sky above the fire, extending! I gasped.

My staff grew heavier than ever. Mire shook and knelt down. I knew the poor deer couldn't hold on any longer. Leg by leg, I shifted my weight onto the ground. I knelt on the ground, clentching the staff with both hands. The water from the

stream was still feeding the growing lake in the air, held up by me!

I couldn't bear it any longer. Every muscle in my body was twitching like mad. Finally, I let go of the water and screamed on top of my lungs: "DOWN!"

WHOOSH!

PLOP!

SPLASH!

SIZZLE!

Then everything went black — I passed out.

* * *

"Emit!"

I heard someone calling me, vaguely, distantly.

"EMIT!"

I popped my eyes open. I was in a daze.

Three pairs of bulging eyes stared down at me.

"He's alive!" I heard someone yell.

Cheers rose from all around me.

"What... what happened?" I mumbled and sat up.

"You put out the fire! You saved the forest!" Came a familiar voice, warm like the sun and gentle like the breeze.

"Mire!" I yelled.

Then I heard laughter of a baby and felt saliva dripping onto my right foot.

"Amber!" I called in joy and delight, held up my baby sister and hugged her.

I heard a benign chuckle. I put Amber down and stood up. Vor stood in front of me. I shook

his large, wrinkled hand.

"Well done, Emit! You proved yourself worthy." Vor's smile seemed too wide for his face.

"Of what?" I asked.

"Look around you."

I glanced around, and was astonished. I was circled by animals, creatures of the forest. Monkeys and squirrels sat on trees, deer and sheep were all around me. A black bear cub stood next to Vor.

Vor cleared his throat and silenced everybody.

"Now, friends of the forest. I hereby present to you Emit, the new Guardian of Nature!"

The crowd of animals roared. The black bear cub reached to me and put a wreath of vines

on my head.

I was honored! I didn't know what to say! So I just stood, blushing and admiring at all that lay before me.

"But what about you?" I asked Vor.

"You know what?" Said the elder, "Today is my 100th birthday. My wish of retirement finally got fulfilled."

That night, I slept on a canopy of soft leaves under the bright cresant moon, listening to the lullaby of the forest, the wind and the stars.

This was certainly the best day of my life.

When I woke up, it was

morning. I found myself... back home, in my bedroom!

I looked around me. No leaves, no animals.

So it was just a dream? I was so disappointed!

Then, my gaze slipped onto my bedside table.

There, lay a staff and a wreath of vines.

My mother's voice came from downstairs.

"Emit! Get up, you lazy dog! We're going on a family trip — to a nature reserve!"

THE END